Call for Participants: IYRP Young Pastoralists Global Gathering of Pastoralist

TITLE: ***Voices of the Land: Young Pastoralists & New technologies Global Gathering***

Or ***Voices of the Land: Global Gathering of Young Pastoralist***

Or ***Our Land. Our Knowledge. Our Decisions: Young Pastoralist Global Gathering***

Introduction:
Greetings! (Greetings in various languages).

We are pleased to invite young pastoralists from across the world to participate in the first Global Gathering of Young Pastoralist 2026 – a meeting to celebrate and strengthen the voices of young pastoralists from around the world. This event brings together young pastoralists, livestock farmers and shepherds whose work connects deeply with land, animals, and community. Whether or not you have traveled regionally and internationally before, your voice and experiences are important - and welcomed.

Meeting Objectives (for more details see the Concept Note):

1. **Build a global network of young pastoralist**, to support ongoing knowledge sharing, mutual support and advocacy, and to ensure young shepherd's voices are represented in decision-making at local, regional and global scales.
2. **Share and learn** knowledge, skills and connections that will advance equality, sustainable pastoralism, and resilient rangelands.
3. **Shape global agendas** for rangeland and pastoralist policy, practice, and that reflect pastoralist youth priorities.
4. **Amplify pastoralist young pastoralists voices** by developing a **strategy to deliver in the global venue of the UNCCD COP 17 in Mongolia** August 2026, and others.

Who This Gathering is For:
We welcome all who self-identify as a young pastoralist and are interested in contributing to this important dialogue. We are seeking participants who are passionate about topics such as pastoralist youth's rights, economic autonomy and development, violence prevention, traditional knowledge and innovations, education and well-being, rangeland restoration, and climate justice, among others.

We invite young pastoralists, from all countries, and from diverse pastoralist systems, including young pastoralists who are part of Indigenous or traditional communities, and young pastoralists who communicate primarily through oral traditions. Assistance can be provided if needed to complete the application.

If you need support completing the application, travel arrangements please feel free to reach out. Below you will find our principles of participation and participant criteria to guide your application, please refer to these criteria when writing an application:

Our Principles of Participation:

- **Inclusion:** We encourage applications from young pastoralists, especially those with limited access to previous opportunities.
- **Cultural Sensitivity:** We honor the traditions and leadership structures of each community while promoting young pastoralists voices.
- **Community Legitimacy:** Participants should be recognized and trusted by their communities.
- **Knowledge Sharing:** Participants commit to sharing what they learn at the Gathering with their communities afterward.

Nominations:

We accept nominations of potential **young pastoralists** participants from the following:

1. young pastoralists's organizations or networks, including regional gatherings of young pastoralists
2. Pastoralist communities or organizations that support young pastoralist
3. Organizations that have agreed to sponsor the Global Gathering of Young Pastoralists
4. Young pastoralists may nominate themselves

In all cases, the potential participants should submit individual applications, indicating how they meet the following criteria. Nominating or sponsoring organizations may assist applicants to complete and submit their application.

Participant Criteria:

1. Identity and Pastoral Experience

- You must be a practicing young pastoralists, actively engaged in grazing-based livestock rearing.
- We welcome young pastoralists from nomadic, transhumant, semi-nomadic and other extensive pastoral systems.

2. Community Representation and Reciprocity

- Ideally, you should be nominated by your community or a pastoralist women's group.
- You are open to represent community ideas, and willing to share your experiences and engage in collaborative discussions.
- You commit to share learning and outcomes with your community when you return home.

3. Advocacy and Indigenous Movements

- Experience in Indigenous peoples' movements or pastoralist advocacy is valued, but not required.
- Even if you have not been involved in formal advocacy, your voice is important.

4. Communication and Language

- You must be able to speak an official language of the Gathering (English, Spanish, French) or attend with a translator as part of your delegation
- We encourage openness to learning and sharing across languages and cultures.

5. Travel Logistics

- You should already have, or be able to obtain, travel documents (such as a passport)

- Sponsoring organizations are encouraged to assist with visas, local & International transport, and costs. So please contact the organization or person who invited you to appy

6. Inclusion and Diversity

- Participants without travel experience are encouraged to travel with a delegation from their region, including a translator. The organizers will help connect you with others travelling from your country or region.

- We especially encourage applications from young pastoralists from Indigenous, and minority pastoralist communities.
    - Young women, elder women, and women with

How to Participate:
If you are interested in participating, please fill out the application form [**provide link to a google form**] or email a copy of your application to [**email address**] no later than January 31 2026.

Anticipated Costs:

A fee of 200 € per participant covers all participant costs within Spain including lodging, breakfasts and dinners, local transportation, and all meeting expenses and materials.

In addition, participants will need to cover their travel costs to and from Madrid-Spain.

Funding Options and Opportunities:

1. Several partner organizations have agreed to sponsor participants from their organizations, regions or projects. If you are nominated by one of these organizations, please indicate this in your application. We will also work to match participants with available sponsors.

2. We may have a limited number of scholarships available to cover the travel costs. Please indicate in your application if you wish to apply for a scholarship. SCHOLARSHIPS WILL BE LIMITED AND WE CANNOT ASSURE FUNDING FOR ANY APPLICANT.
3. Participants may fund themselves.

Submission Requirements:

- A brief personal biography (max 250 words).
- A short letter explaining why you wish to attend, what you hope to contribute, and how participation will benefit you and your community (500-1000 words). Be sure to address other relevant participant criteria outlined above. If written responses aren't feasible, you may submit a short video (<3 minutes) that includes the same information.
- A brief letter of support from your community (such as local government or traditional leader), or an organization, network, or project you have participated in.
- Statement of funding needs.

Application Evaluation:

The organizers will evaluate applications based on each applicant's potential contributions to and benefits from the gathering as well as other criteria listed above.

The organisers will also consider representation from pastoralist regions around the world.

Key dates

- **Application Deadline:** January 31, 2026
- **Notification of Acceptance:** February 15, 2026
- **Registration (and payment by sponsor):** February 20, 2026
- **Official Letters of Invitation Sent:** As soon as registration and payment are received
- **Travel Arrangements (i.e. airline ticket purchase) Should be Completed No Later than:** March 15, 2026 [Note, participants must arrive in Madrid by April 8, 2026]
- **Lodging and Meals:** Lodging and lunch are Provided in the gathering fee. All participants will stay in the Youth Hostel of Alcala de Hernares and reservations will be made by IMIDRA. IMIDRA will provide transportation to and from the Youth Hostel to event Venue in Madrid each day.
- **Meeting Dates:** April 09-10-11, 2026 (arrival no later than April 8, departure on April 12)
- **Location:** XXXXXX In Madrid.

DRAFT APPLICATION FORM (TO BE ON-LINE GOOGLE FORM OR PAPER EQUIVALENT)

First Name (Given Name):

Last Name (Family Name):

Community/Town/District:

State/Province:

Country:

Date of Birth:

Languages: (please list all of the languages that you can speak and understand)

Email (if possible):

Phone number (required):

NOTE: Please complete the following sections in one of the official meeting languages (English, Spanish, French, Arabic, Hindi, Nepali). Use of one of these languages is preferred. If necessary, you may complete in a different language and we will seek appropriate translation.

Biographical statement. Please tell us about your background, pastoralist experience, and community involvement. (250 word limit)

Please explain why you want to attend the Young Pastoralists Global Gathering, what you can contribute and how participation will benefit you and your community. Be sure to address any relevant participant criteria outlined in the Call for Participation. (500-1000 words or 3 min video)

Letter of Support: Please attach/upload a brief letter of support from your community (such as local government or traditional leader), or an organization, network, or project you have participated in. The letter should address your ability to represent your community's priorities and concerns and to share your learning with community members when you return.

Funding Needs: Please let us know more about how you expect to cover the costs of attendance. (check the box that best applies) Funding needs will not be considered in reviewing applications.

___ A sponsor has agreed to support my participation

___ My organization will support my participation

___ I can cover all my own costs

___ I can cover my travel to Madrid, but not the 200 € local maintenance

___ I can cover the the 200 € local maintenance fee, but not my travel to Madrid

___ I do not have a sponsor and will need a scholarship to cover all of my costs